known outside of China. [16] Others are not what they seem, although at first glance similar institutions may also be found in democratic countries. Over the years, these Chinese actors have skilfully inserted themselves into the political systems of democracies and gained legitimacy, without the democratic state realizing either their objectives or their role in shaping perceptions. Since they form crucial moving parts of the Chinese negotiating machine, it is, therefore, important to elaborate on them.

The first of these is the United Front Work Department (*Zhongyang Tongyi Zhanxian Gongzuo Bu* or UFWD). It is an organ of the Chinese Communist Party that was first set up in the 1920s to unite internal political forces against the ruling Chinese Nationalist Party (Kuomintang) during the Chinese Civil War, so that the population did not focus their fears on the Communist takeover. Mao Zedong described the UFWD as one of his three 'magic' weapons. Although the principal work of the UFWD is still domestic in nature, since 1949, the UFWD has also been tasked to carry out influencer activities abroad. This is done in two ways. It mobilizes Chinese entrepreneurs, academics, cultural and religious figures to do propaganda abroad and to influence key elites or individuals in the target countries; and it persuades and even coerces overseas Chinese communities to gather information or to influence people in their countries of adoption. The UFWD has massively expanded its remit since General Secretary Xi Jinping took office in 2012. He convened a national-level conference in May 2015 that vastly strengthened the UFWD by bringing key organs like the State Ethnic Affairs Commission and the State Administration of Religious Affairs within its ambit. [17]

New regulations (*Zhongguo Gongchandang Tongyi Zhanxian Gongzuo Tiaoli*) were enacted and a Central Small Leading Group to direct UFWD activities with Xi Jinping as the head was